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CUET UG

History

Vijayanagara Empire: Politics, Economy & Architecture

Theme 7 · An Imperial Capital: Vijayanagara (c. 14th – 16th Century) · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

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Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

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Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit VII Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
Discovery & Historiography	Colin Mackenzie (1800); oral traditions of Virupaksha and Pampadevi; First Surveyor General (1815); Alexander Greenlaw photography (1856); J.F. Fleet epigraphy (1876); John Marshall (1902); UNESCO 1986.	Evaluating archaeological discovery timelines; matching survey methods; analyzing cartographic and epigraphic recovery techniques.
Foreign Travel Accounts	Nicolo de Conti (1420); Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi (1440s); Duarte Barbosa (c. 1518); Domingo Paes (c. 1520–1522); Fernao Nuniz (c. 1535–1537); urban observations, horse trade, and fortification records.	Evaluating foreign primary sources; identifying travelers' home origins and reigning monarchs visited; assessing ethnographic reliability.
Dynasties & State Expansion	Foundation (1336 CE) by Harihara I and Bukka I; Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva, and Aravidu dynasties; Sacred geography (Kishkindha, Pampadevi, Virupaksha); **Sri Virupaksha** signet; **Hindu Suratrana** title.	Ordering dynastic chronologies; analyzing sacred legitimation strategies; differentiating royal titular styles.
Krishnadeva Raya & Talikota	Tuluva zenith (1509–1529); Raichur Doab conquest (1512); Orissa Gajapatis (1514); Nagalapuram township; **Amuktamalyada** (Telugu); Battle of Talikota / Rakshasi-Tangadi (1565); Aravidu relocation.	Evaluating military campaigns; literary attribution; analyzing geopolitical causes and consequences of imperial decline.
Amaranayakas & Economy	**Amaranayaka** system (derived from Sultanate **Iqta**); military contingents; tax collection; annual tribute; **kudirai chettis** (horse merchants); Portuguese trade monopoly; luxury textile and gem commerce.	Contrasting feudal military tenures; analyzing fiscal mechanics of resource extraction; evaluating trans-oceanic trade dynamics.
Hydraulics & Monumental Arts	Tungabhadra granite basin; Kamalapuram tank; Hiriya canal; Abdur Razzaq's 7 concentric walls; Royal Centre (Mahanavami Dibba, Lotus Mahal, Hazara Rama); Sacred Centre (Virupaksha, Vitthala, **rayagopurams**).	Analyzing medieval urban engineering; evaluating ritual statecraft architecture; identifying synthesis of Dravidian and Indo-Islamic styles.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 7 is one of the highest-scoring chapters in CUET UG History. Master these critical distinctions:

1. **Dynastic Succession Sequence:**

   Sangama (1336–1485) → **Saluva** (1485–1505) → **Tuluva** (1505–1570) → **Aravidu** (1570–c. 1646)

Harihara I and Bukka I founded the **Sangama** dynasty; **Krishnadeva Raya** belonged to the **Tuluva** dynasty; the post-Talikota rulers belonged to the **Aravidu** dynasty.

2. **Traveler Matchings:**
   - **Nicolo de Conti:** Italian merchant (visited c. 1420 under Devaraya I).
   - **Abdur Razzaq:** Persian ambassador from Herat (visited c. 1440s under Devaraya II; recorded **7 concentric fortification walls**).
   - **Duarte Barbosa:** Portuguese official (visited c. 1518 under Krishnadeva Raya; recorded trade and customs).
   - **Domingo Paes:** Portuguese horse trader (visited c. 1520–1522 under Krishnadeva Raya; detailed eyewitness of **Mahanavami Dibba**).
   - **Fernao Nuniz:** Portuguese horse dealer (visited c. 1535–1537 under Achyuta Deva Raya; chronicled the **Amaranayaka** system).
3. **Literary Works of Krishnadeva Raya: Amuktamalyada** was composed in **Telugu** (on statecraft and Andal's wedding); **Jambavati Kalyanam** was composed in **Sanskrit**.
4. **The Seven Fortification Walls:** Abdur Razzaq noted that the outer fortification walls encircled agricultural fields, orchards, and gardens, designed to withstand protracted sieges.
5. **Battle of Talikota:** Fought on **23 January 1565** (also called the Battle of **Rakshasi-Tangadi**). The combined armies of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, and Golconda defeated Rama Raya.

1. Discovery and Historiographical Recovery of Hampi

The ruins of Vijayanagara, popularly known as **Hampi** (derived from the local river goddess **Pampadevi**), were brought to modern historical light in **1800** by **Colonel Colin Mackenzie**:

- **Early Cartography:** Mackenzie, an engineer and cartographer of the English East India Company, prepared the first topological survey map of the site. His initial reconstructions relied on:
  - Firsthand physical surveys of the granite hills and river basin.
  - Oral traditions and memories preserved by the hereditary priests (**archakas**) of the functioning Virupaksha temple and the Pampadevi shrine.
  - Inscriptions carved in Kannada, Telugu, Sanskrit, and Tamil found on temple walls, gateways, and copper-plate charters.
- **Surveyor General of India:** In **1815**, Mackenzie was appointed as the **first Surveyor General of India**, establishing systematic archival documentation across South India.
- **Photographic and Epigraphic Documentation:**
  - In **1856**, photographer **Alexander Greenlaw** took the earliest extensive photographs of Hampi's monuments, preserving invaluable records of structures before modern weathering.
  - In **1876**, epigraphist **J.F. Fleet** began systematic documentation and translation of stone inscriptions.
  - In **1902**, under Director General **John Marshall**, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) undertook structured conservation.
  - In **1986**, Hampi was declared a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**, following intensive documentation by international researchers (including George Michell and John Fritz).

2. Foreign Travellers' Accounts: Windows into the Imperial City

Foreign merchants and diplomatic envoys provided vivid eyewitness accounts that allow historians to cross-examine indigenous epigraphic and literary records:

Traveler	Origin	Reign Visited	Primary Historiographical Observations
Nicolo de Conti	Italian merchant	Devaraya I (c. 1420)	Recorded the immense perimeter of the city, its massive population, and annual festive celebrations.
Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi	Persian ambassador	Devaraya II (c. 1440s)	Described the **seven concentric lines of fortifications** that encircled agricultural fields, orchards, and urban zones.
Duarte Barbosa	Portuguese official	Krishnadeva Raya (c. 1518)	Detailed accounts of bustling jewel markets, pearls, diamond trading, and wide religious toleration across the city.
Domingo Paes	Portuguese visitor	Krishnadeva Raya (c. 1520–22)	Left graphic eyewitness descriptions of the **Mahanavami Dibba** ceremonies, palace interiors, irrigation tanks, and royal reviews.
Fernao Nuniz	Portuguese horse dealer	Achyuta Deva Raya (c. 1535–37)	Chronicled dynastic political history, wars, and the detailed revenue and military obligations of the **Amaranayaka** system.

3. Dynastic Evolution & The Zenith of Krishnadeva Raya

The Vijayanagara Empire was founded in **1336 CE** by two brothers, **Harihara I** and **Bukka I**, of the **Sangama dynasty**. The capital was established on the southern bank of the **Tungabhadra** river, amidst rugged natural granite crags.

Sacred Geography & Legitimation

The location was chosen to weave imperial power into deep regional sacred mythology:

- The site was identified with the mythical monkey kingdom of **Kishkindha** from the **Ramayana**.
- The craggy granite hills were revered as the hermitage where the local river goddess **Pampadevi** performed penance to marry Lord **Virupaksha** (a manifestation of Shiva).
- The monarchs claimed to rule as proxies of Lord Virupaksha. Royal decrees were formally signed with the Kannada invocation **"Sri Virupaksha"**. Kings also assumed the hybrid Sanskritized title **"Hindu Suratrana"** (meaning "Sultan among Hindu Kings"), signaling ideological parity with contemporary northern Sultanates.

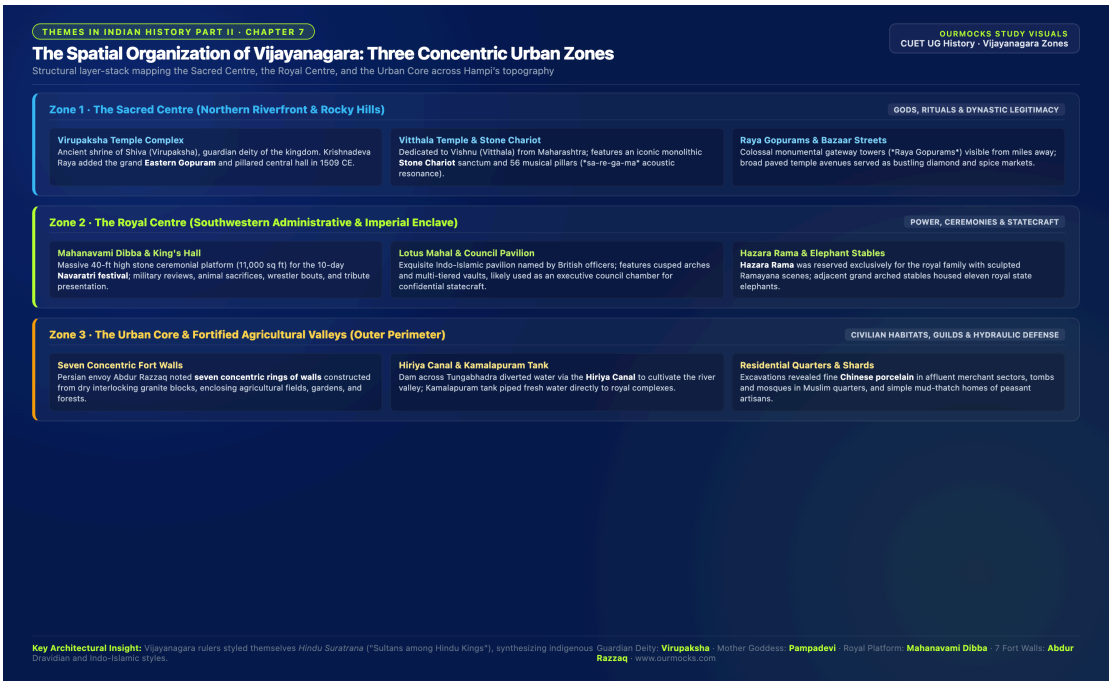


Figure 1: Figure 1 — Spatial Topography of Vijayanagara: Structural layering illustrating the Sacred Centre along the river, Urban Core residential tracts, and fortified Royal Centre.

The Four Dynasties of Vijayanagara

1. **Sangama Dynasty (1336–1485 CE):** Founded the empire; waged prolonged wars against the Bahmani Sultanate over the fertile **Raichur Doab** (the interfluvial territory between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers) and Krishna-Godavari delta ports.
2. **Saluva Dynasty (1485–1505 CE):** Military commanders (**saluvas**) seized the throne through a military coup to stabilize the empire after Sangama factional strife.
3. **Tuluva Dynasty (1505–1570 CE):** Reached the pinnacle of military expansion, architectural grandeur, and economic prosperity under **Krishnadeva Raya**.
4. **Aravidu Dynasty (1570–c. 1646 CE):** Founded by Tirumala after the disaster of Talikota, ruling from the southern fortresses of **Penukonda** and **Chandragiri**.

The Reign of Krishnadeva Raya (1509–1529 CE)

Krishnadeva Raya's twenty-year rule was marked by unprecedented imperial consolidation:

- **Military Triumphs:** Subjugated the fertile **Raichur Doab** in 1512; defeated the Gajapati ruler of Orissa (Prataparudra), capturing the hill fort of Udayagiri (1514) and Kondavidu (1515); inflicted crushing defeats upon Sultan Ismail Adil Shah of Bijapur.
- **Architectural Splendor:** Commissioned the magnificent eastern **rayagopuram** and added an exquisite pillared hall (**mandapa**) in front of the inner shrine of the Virupaksha Temple.
- **Suburban Foundation:** Established the township of **Nagalapuram** near Vijayanagara in memory of his beloved mother, Nagala Devi.
- **Literary Brilliance:** A polymath, he authored the renowned treatise on statecraft, **Amuktamalyada**, in **Telugu**, and composed the Sanskrit drama **Jambavati Kalyanam**. His royal court was adorned by the **Ashtadiggajas** (eight eminent Telugu poets), foremost among them Allasani Peddana.

The Catastrophe at Talikota (1565 CE)

Following Krishnadeva Raya's death, imperial stability eroded under court rivalries:

- **Aliya Rama Raya's Geopolitical Gamble:** The chief minister, Rama Raya, adopted a dangerous, cynical policy of playing off the rival Deccan Sultanates (Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Golconda, and Bidar) against one another.
- **The Grand Coalition:** Frustrated by his manipulative interventions, the Deccan Sultans united in an unprecedented military alliance.
- **The Battle of Talikota:** On **23 January 1565**, the combined Sultanate armies decisively crushed the Vijayanagara forces at **Rakshasi-Tangadi** (Talikota). Rama Raya was captured and executed. Within weeks, the victorious armies sacked and burned the imperial city of Hampi, leaving it permanently desolate. The surviving royal lineage fled southward, continuing fragmented rule from Penukonda under the Aravidu dynasty.

4. Military Feudalism & Economy: The Amaranayaka System

The institutional bedrock of the Vijayanagara imperial state was the **Amaranayaka system**, which adapted and evolved the **Iqta** system of the Delhi Sultanate:

- **Military Governors (**Amaranayakas**):** Military commanders (**nayakas**) were assigned defined territories (**amaram**) to govern. The word **amara** is believed to derive from the Sanskrit **samara** (battle) or the Persian **amir** (noble).
- **Fiscal & Military Obligations:**
  - Nayakas collected land revenue, customs duties, and craft taxes from peasants, artisans, and traders within their assigned domain.
  - They retained a portion of revenue for personal maintenance and for equipping a fixed contingent of horses, elephants, and infantry.
  - These contingents provided the imperial monarch with a formidable standing strike force during external wars.
  - A portion of revenue was earmarked for maintaining local temples and irrigation tanks.
- **Imperial Oversight & Subjugation:**
  - Amaranayakas were required to travel personally to the imperial capital annually to present gifts and pay fixed cash tribute directly to the Emperor.
  - The king asserted sovereign dominance by periodically transferring nayakas from one province to another to prevent the crystallization of hereditary regional power bases.

Horse Trade & Commercial Prosperity

Cavalry was critical for victory in medieval warfare:

- **The Arabian Horse Monopoly:** Local horses in southern India were ill-suited for heavy cavalry warfare. Rulers imported thousands of high-quality Arabian and Central Asian war-horses through western ports.
- **Kudirai Chettis:** Local merchant syndicates specializing in the horse trade were known as **kudirai chettis** ("horse merchants").
- **The Portuguese Intervention:** In 1510, the Portuguese captured Goa under Afonso de Albuquerque, establishing an armed naval monopoly over the importation of Arabian horses. Krishnadeva Raya cultivated close diplomatic and trade ties with the Portuguese to secure exclusive access to imported cavalry mounts and advanced European firearms (**muskets** and cannons).

5. Urban Geography & Hydraulic Civil Engineering

Vijayanagara was situated in the semi-arid Deccan plateau, nestled in a natural granite amphitheater formed by the rushing waters of the **Tungabhadra** river:

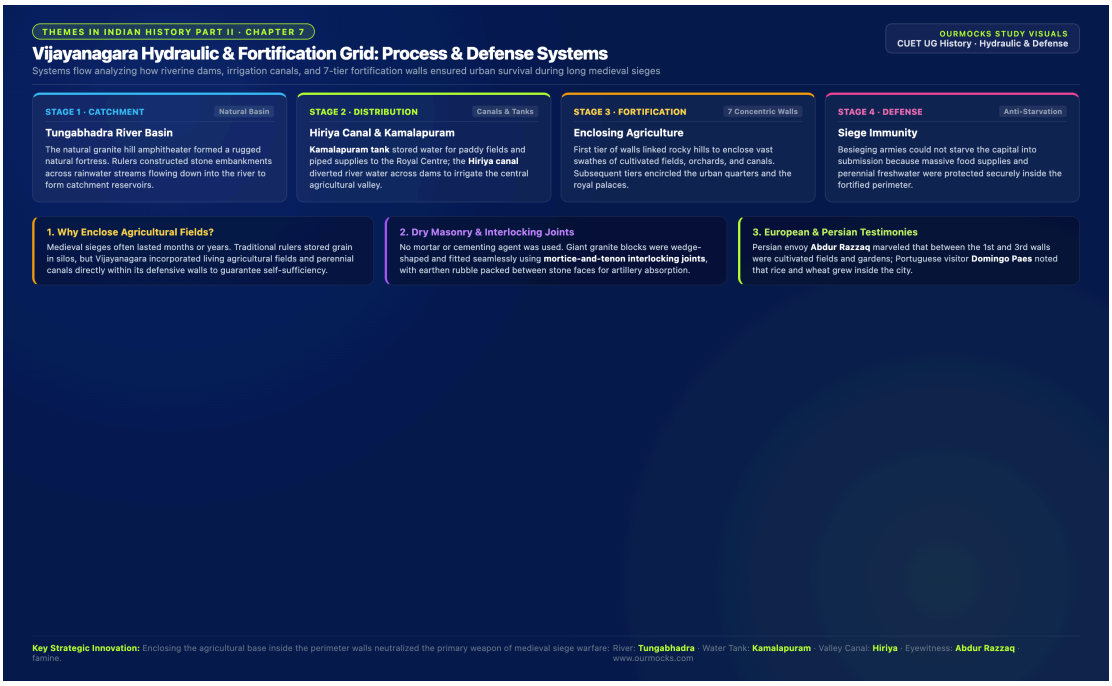


Figure 2: Figure 2 — Imperial Hydraulic Grid of Vijayanagara: Water flow architecture tracing catchment from the Tungabhadra river, Kamalapuram storage reservoir, and Hiriya masonry canal network.

To sustain a massive imperial population exceeding 500,000 citizens in an arid landscape, the Rayas pioneered extraordinary civil engineering works:

- **Granite Granite Runoff Catchment:** Numerous seasonal streams flowed down from surrounding boulder-strewn hills into the Tungabhadra. Engineers constructed masonry embankments across these streams to create water storage reservoirs of various capacities.
- **The Kamalapuram Tank:** Built in the early 15th century, this immense masonry reservoir collected monsoon runoff. It served a dual purpose: irrigating surrounding agricultural fields and feeding a deep stone aqueduct that conveyed water directly into the Royal Centre.
- **The Hiriya Canal:** Constructed under the early Sangama monarchs, this monumental canal drew water directly from a dam built across the Tungabhadra, winding through a scenic valley to irrigate cultivated tracts separating the Sacred Centre from the Urban Core.

The Seven Lines of Fortifications

The Persian ambassador **Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi**, visiting the city in the 1440s, recorded that Vijayanagara was encircled by **seven concentric rings of massive fortification walls**:

- **Wedge-Shaped Masonry:** The walls were constructed using massive, dry-jointed granite blocks without any mortar or cementing material. The stones were cut into wedge shapes, dovetailing together so tightly that they were virtually indestructible against battering rams.
- **Agricultural Enclosure:** Crucially, Abdur Razzaq noted that between the first, second, and third outer rings of walls lay vast stretches of cultivated agricultural land, rice fields, gardens, and orchards fed by the Hiriya canal.
- **Strategic Siege Rationale:** Medieval sieges were aimed at starving fortified cities into surrender. By enclosing expansive agricultural lands within the outer fortress walls, Vijayanagara could cultivate its own food supply indefinitely, rendering enemy siege blockades futile!

6. The Royal Centre & Ritual Statecraft

The **Royal Centre**, situated in the southwestern zone of the settlement, contained over thirty distinct palace structures, ceremonial platforms, and elite temples:

The Mahanavami Dibba: Monumental Theater of Power

The **Mahanavami Dibba** is a colossal granite platform rising in three diminishing tiers to a height of nearly **40 feet**, covering a base area of **11,000 square feet**:

- **Friezes of Daily Life:** The exterior granite face of the platform is embellished with exquisitely sculpted relief carvings depicting royal processions, hunting scenes, war elephants, foreign horse merchants, dancing women, and acrobats.
- **The Ten-Day Mahanavami Festival:** The platform formed the liturgical epicenter of the annual ten-day **Mahanavami** festival (occurring in autumn, celebrating the goddess Durga's victory over Mahishasura, celebrated today as Dussehra or Navaratri).
- **Rituals of Sovereign Legitimation:**
  - Worship of the state horse, image of the deity, and royal arms.
  - Sacrifices of buffalos and sheep.
  - Athletic wrestling matches, firework displays, and dances performed before the king.
  - The culminating ritual was the grand review of the imperial army on the tenth day (**Vijayadashami**), where all Amaranayakas assembled their disciplined cavalry, war elephants, and infantry in a magnificent open plain before the Emperor, presenting their annual cash tributes.

Other Notable Royal Structures

- **The Lotus Mahal:** An exquisite two-storied pavilion featuring nine arched bays. It represents a masterly synthesis of traditional Dravidian brackets with Indo-Islamic cusped arches and multi-tiered stucco vaulting. British antiquarians named it the Lotus Mahal, though Colin Mackenzie's map suggests it functioned as a confidential council chamber where the king met with his innermost military advisers.
- **The Elephant Stables:** Located adjacent to the Lotus Mahal, a colossal rectangular building with eleven vaulted brick-and-mortar domes, housing the emperor's prized royal war elephants.
- **The Hazara Rama Temple:** Located in the heart of the Royal Centre, this was the private royal family chapel. Its interior walls feature intricately sculpted stone bas-reliefs narrating the complete storyline of the **Ramayana**.

7. The Urban Core & Everyday Life: Archaeological Discoveries

While monumental stone temples and royal platforms have survived the centuries, reconstructing the routine daily lives of the ordinary inhabitants of Vijayanagara presents unique archaeological challenges:

Houses of the Common People

- **Perishable Architecture:** Unlike royal palaces and temples constructed of massive granite blocks, the houses of commoners, agricultural laborers, and artisans were built of perishable materials—mud, unbaked brick, timber, and thatch. Consequently, little domestic architecture survives above ground level.
- **Barbosa's Eyewitness Description:** The Portuguese traveler Duarte Barbosa observed the vibrant street layouts: **"The other houses of the people are thatched, but nonetheless**

well built and arranged according to occupations, in long streets with many open places."

- **Occupational Segregation:** Urban settlements were organized along occupational streets—weavers, metal-smiths, potters, and oil-pressers inhabited distinct municipal lanes (**keris**).

The Muslim Residential Quarter & Chinese Porcelain

- **Islamic Presence in the Imperial City:** Extensive field surveys conducted by the Vijayanagara Research Project in the northeastern corner of the Urban Core uncovered numerous tombs and mosques.
- **Architectural Hybridity:** Interestingly, the mosques in this quarter adopted local architectural vocabulary, incorporating stone pillar brackets and stepped mouldings resembling temple mandapas.
- **Elite Material Culture:** In the same elite residential sector, archaeologists uncovered numerous fragments of imported fine **Chinese porcelain**. This discovery confirms foreign traveler accounts that wealthy Muslim merchants, high-ranking military commanders, and diplomatic envoys resided in this prestigious quarter, engaging in trans-Asian luxury commerce.

The Great Temple Bazaars

The economic vitality of Vijayanagara was concentrated in the wide, straight avenues leading directly to temple gateways:

- **Virupaksha Bazaar:** Stretching eastward from the Virupaksha temple, this monumental paved avenue measured over **700 meters in length and 30 meters in width**, flanked on both sides by continuous two-storied colonnaded stone shops.
- **Abundance of Commodities:** Portuguese visitors expressed astonishment at the sheer abundance of luxury goods displayed openly in these markets: sacks of unrefined and cut diamonds, emeralds, rubies, fine seed-pearls from the Gulf of Mannar, delicate Gujarati chintz, and Kashmiri silks. Domingo Paes famously remarked that the markets were so bursting with provisions and wealth that the city seemed like a realm of fairy tales.

Hydraulic Engineering within the Royal Enclosures

Beyond the Kamalapuram reservoir, intensive excavations in the Royal Centre uncovered an intricate urban water grid:

- **Over Sixty Reservoirs:** Archaeologists have identified more than **60 individual tanks, wells, and cisterns** within the royal sector alone.
- **The Stepped Tank (Kalyani):** A masterwork of geometric stone masonry, excavated near the Mahanavami Dibba. Crafted from precisely dressed chlorite stone blocks numbered with mason's marks, it was supplied by stone conduits that channeled fresh water from external storage reservoirs into the stepped pool for royal ablutions.
- **The Queen's Bath:** An ornate square pleasure pavilion featuring a central water pool surrounded by an open corridor with projecting carved **jharokha** balconies, vaulted stucco ceilings, and lotus-bud fountain nozzles, synthesizing Deccan Islamic bathhouse design with indigenous courtly aesthetics.

7. The Sacred Centre: Architectural Magnificence & Devotion

The **Sacred Centre** occupied the rocky northern zone overlooking the rocky rapids of the Tungabhadra:

The Virupaksha Temple Complex

Dedicated to Lord Virupaksha, the guardian deity of the realm, the temple developed over multiple centuries:

- **Ancient Core:** The earliest shrines date back to the 9th–10th century under the Rashtrakutas and Hoysalas.
- **Krishnadeva Raya's Additions:** In 1509–1510 CE, to commemorate his coronation, Krishnadeva Raya constructed the monumental eastern **rayagopuram** (entrance gateway) and the grand pillared assembly hall (**mandapa**) in front of the sanctum, adorned with finely carved granite pillars depicting rearing mythical beasts (**yalis**).

The Vitthala Temple Complex

The **Vitthala Temple** is universally celebrated as the architectural climax of Vijayanagara art:

- **Deity:** Dedicated to **Vitthala**, a manifestation of Vishnu traditionally worshipped in Maharashtra (Pandharpur). The presence of this shrine highlights the cosmopolitan religious syncretism of the Vijayanagara emperors, who incorporated regional cults to unify diverse subcontinental territories.
- **The Stone Chariot (**Ratha**):** In the courtyard stands the iconic monolithic-style stone chariot shrine dedicated to Garuda (the vehicle of Vishnu). Its wheels were carved as revolving stone discs.
- **The Musical Pillars:** The principal **mandapa** contains 56 magnificent granite pillars intricately sculpted with slender secondary shafts, which produce distinct musical notes (**swaras**) when tapped.
- **Kalyana Mandapas:** Elaborate open pillared pavilions designed for celebrating the ceremonial annual marriage of the temple deity with his divine consort, featuring dynamic sculptures of musicians, dancers, and celestial beings.
- **Rayagopurams (Royal Gateways):** Monumental entrance towers constructed by the Rayas, often exceeding 150 feet in height, towering above the surrounding landscape to broadcast imperial majesty and pious generosity across vast distances.

Temples as Economic and Political Institutions

In the Vijayanagara Empire, temple complexes were far more than places of worship:

- **Corporate Landlords:** Kings, queens, and military nayakas bestowed extensive tax-free agricultural lands (**devadana** or **brahmadeya**) upon temples. The temple trusts managed these vast agrarian estates, collecting agricultural produce, constructing storage granaries, and hiring hundreds of priests, dancers, musicians, accountants, and sweepers.
- **Agrarian Capital Investment:** Temple administrations actively invested surplus monetary endowments into digging village irrigation tanks, reclaiming wasteland, and advancing credit loans to local peasant cultivators, driving the agricultural expansion of the southern dry zone.
- **Ritual Validation of Statecraft:** By liberally financing temple expansions, adding royal gopurams, and participating in divine marriage rituals, Vijayanagara rulers publicly bound their imperial authority to local deities, transforming regional religious fervor into a durable foundation for dynastic loyalty.

The Architectural Legacy: From Hampi to Penukonda and the Nayaka Dynasties

The architectural and urban achievements of Vijayanagara left a permanent imprint on the cultural geography of southern India:

- **Continuity Under the Aravidu Rulers:** Although the imperial capital at Hampi was permanently abandoned after the catastrophic sack of 1565, the architectural traditions of the empire did not perish. The Aravidu dynasty, operating from their southern administrative centers at **Penukonda** and later **Chandragiri**, continued patronizing monumental temple works and fortified palace citadels.
- **The Nayaka Architectural Floreat:** Regional military governors (**nayakas**) who broke away from imperial control to establish independent dynasties in Tamil Nadu—most prominently the Nayakas of **Madurai**, **Thanjavur**, and **Senji** (Jinji)—directly inherited and elaborated Vijayanagara aesthetic models:
  - **Colossal Gopurams:** They constructed soaring multi-tiered gopurams that dominated regional skylines, as seen in the Meenakshi Sundareswarar temple complex at Madurai.
  - **Thousand-Pillared Halls & Composite Columns:** They built vast **ayirakkal mandapas** (thousand-pillared halls) featuring monumental rearing mythical beasts (**yalis**) mounted by warriors, dynamic stone brackets, and intricately sculpted granite friezes.
  - **Pudumandapa & Corridor Architecture:** The Nayakas expanded temple enclosures with immense, cool pillared corridors and ceremonial marriage pavilions (**Kalyana Mandapas**), demonstrating the enduring institutional and artistic vitality of the Vijayanagara heritage across the early modern era.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Vijayanagara Empire Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of Colin Mackenzie's discovery, foreign travel chronicles, dynastic chronologies, hydraulic networks, Amaranayaka feudalism, and monumental temple architecture.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **Chronological Sequence of Dynasties:** (1) **Sangama** (1336) -> (2) **Saluva** (1485) -> (3) **Tuluva** (1505) -> (4) **Aravidu** (1570).
- **Colin Mackenzie (1800):** Prepared first map of Hampi; first Surveyor General of India in **1815**; collected oral traditions from Virupaksha priests.
- **Krishnadeva Raya (1509–1529):** Belonged to **Tuluva** dynasty; conquered **Raichur Doab** (1512); founded **Nagalapuram**; authored **Amuktamalyada** (**Telugu**) & **Jambavati Kalyanam** (**Sanskrit**).
- **Battle of Talikota:** Fought on **23 January 1565** (also **Rakshasi-Tangadi**); coalition of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, and Golconda crushed Rama Raya.
- **Amaranayaka System:** Military commanders holding land (**amaram**); maintained troops and elephants; paid annual tribute in person; based on Sultanate **Iqta**.
- **Foreign Travelers: Abdur Razzaq** (7 concentric walls enclosing fields); **Domingo Paes** (Mahanavami Dibba); **Fernao Nuniz** (Amaranayaka system); **Duarte Barbosa** (trade & jewels).
- **Hydraulics: Kamalapuram Tank** (reservoir + aqueduct); **Hiriya Canal** (dam on Tungabhadra to irrigate agricultural fields).
- **Sacred vs Royal Architecture: Mahanavami Dibba** (40-ft platform, Navaratri review); **Lotus Mahal** (Indo-Islamic council chamber); **Vitthala Temple** (stone chariot, musical pillars); **Hazara Rama** (Ramayana reliefs).

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — VIJAYANAGARA EMPIRE

- **Sacred Sovereignty Titulature:** Kings ruled on behalf of Lord Virupaksha, signing edicts as **"Sri Virupaksha"** in Kannada, while adopting the title **"Hindu Suratrana"** ("Sultan among Hindu Kings").
- **Strategic Agricultural Enclosure:** Abdur Razzaq's record of enclosing fields between outer fortification walls was designed to prevent starvation during protracted siege warfare.
- **Amaranayaka vs Central Bureaucrat:** Nayakas were feudal military commanders with territorial tax rights (**amaram**), not fixed cash-salaried civil servants.
- **Horse Trade Diplomacy:** The Portuguese controlled the sea routes and imported Arabian horses; Vijayanagara secured a monopoly through diplomatic alliances with Albuquerque.
- **Deccan Architectural Synthesis:** Vijayanagara combined traditional South Indian granite craftsmanship (Dravidian brackets, **rayagopurams**) with Indo-Islamic stucco arches and domes (Lotus Mahal, Elephant Stables).

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **Trap 1 (Krishnadeva Raya's Dynasty):** Mistaking him for a Sangama ruler. He belonged to the **Tuluva** dynasty (1509–1529).
2. **Trap 2 (Language of Amuktamalyada):** Assuming it was in Kannada. **Amuktamalyada** was written in **Telugu**; his Sanskrit drama was **Jambavati Kalyanam**.
3. **Trap 3 (Seven Walls Area):** Believing the 7 walls only encircled the royal palace. The outer 3 walls enclosed **cultivated fields and forests**.
4. **Trap 4 (Fate After Talikota):** Thinking the empire ceased to exist in 1565. The capital Hampi was destroyed, but the empire continued under the **Aravidu** dynasty from Penukonda.
5. **Trap 5 (Vitthala's Provenance):** Assuming Vitthala was a traditional Tamil deity. Vitthala was a manifestation of Vishnu worshipped in **Maharashtra** (Pandharpur).
6. **Trap 6 (Mahanavami Dibba Material):** Believing it was built of imported marble. It was crafted entirely of **local granite stone**.
7. **Trap 7 (First Surveyor General):** Confusing John Marshall or Alexander Cunningham with Colin Mackenzie. **Colin Mackenzie** became the first Surveyor General of India in **1815**.

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: Historiography, Dynasties & Foreign Travellers (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. In which year did Colonel Colin Mackenzie, an engineer and cartographer of the English East India Company, first bring the historical ruins of Hampi to modern academic notice?

(A) 1757 CE (B) 1800 CE
(C) 1856 CE (D) 1902 CE

Sol. Q1. Discovery of Hampi:

- In **1800 CE**, **Colonel Colin Mackenzie** discovered the ruins of Hampi, preparing the first topological survey map based on site inspections and interviews with Virupaksha priests.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q2. Which ruling dynasty of the Vijayanagara Empire did the renowned monarch Emperor Krishnadeva Raya (reigned 1509–1529 CE) belong to?

(A) Sangama dynasty (B) Saluva dynasty
(C) Tuluva dynasty (D) Aravidu dynasty

Sol. Q2. Dynasty of Krishnadeva Raya:

- Krishnadeva Raya belonged to the **Tuluva** dynasty (founded by Vira Narasimha), ruling during the golden zenith of Vijayanagara from 1509 to 1529 CE.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q3. Which foreign traveler to Vijayanagara left the celebrated eyewitness description of the seven concentric lines of fortification walls enclosing agricultural fields, orchards, and gardens?

(A) Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi (B) Nicolo de Conti
(C) Duarte Barbosa (D) Domingo Paes

Sol. Q3. Abdur Razzaq on Fortifications:

- **Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi**, the Persian ambassador from Herat who visited Vijayanagara in the 1440s during Devaraya II's reign, documented the **seven concentric lines of fortifications**.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q4. In which classical language did Emperor Krishnadeva Raya compose his celebrated treatise on statecraft, kingship, and devotional governance titled 'Amuktamalyada'?

(A) Kannada (B) Sanskrit
(C) Tamil (D) Telugu

Sol. Q4. Language of Amuktamalyada:

- Krishnadeva Raya composed his masterpiece **Amuktamalyada** in **Telugu**.
- He also composed the drama **Jambavati Kalyanam** in Sanskrit.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q5. The disastrous Battle of Talikota (also known as the Battle of Rakshasi-Tangadi), which resulted in the sacking and devastation of Vijayanagara, was fought in which year?

(A) 1565 CE (B) 1526 CE
(C) 1556 CE (D) 1576 CE

Sol. Q5. Battle of Talikota Date:

- The Battle of Talikota took place on **23 January 1565 CE**, when the combined armies of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, and Golconda defeated the Vijayanagara army commanded by Aliya Rama Raya.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Part 2: Statecraft, Amaranayakas & Hydraulic Engineering (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. The Amaranayaka system, which formed the primary military-fiscal foundation of Vijayanagara governance, was directly derived and adapted from which earlier institutional model?

(A) The Mansabdari system of the Mughal Empire
(B) The Iqta system of the Delhi Sultanate
(C) The Nayankara system of the Kakatiyas
(D) The Mirasdari land tenure of the Cholas

Sol. Q6. Origins of Amaranayaka System:

- NCERT explicitly notes that the **Amaranayaka system** was a major political innovation of the Vijayanagara Empire, derived directly from the **Iqta system** of the Delhi Sultanate.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q7. What were the annual administrative and symbolic obligations required of the Amaranayakas towards the Vijayanagara Emperor?

(A) Sending their children as perpetual hostages to the capital
(B) Surrendering all rights to collect land revenues from peasants
(C) Appearing personally at court annually with gifts and fixed cash tribute
(D) Undertaking naval expeditions to Southeast Asia

Sol. Q7. Obligations of Amaranayakas:

- Amaranayakas collected revenue from their territories (**amaram**), maintained military contingents, and personally presented annual gifts and fixed cash tribute to the King at the capital.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q8. Local South Indian merchant communities who actively engaged in the highly lucrative trade of importing Arabian and Central Asian war horses were historically designated as:

(A) Chettiars
(B) Banjaras
(C) Marwaris
(D) Kudirai Chettis

Sol. Q8. The Kudirai Chettis:

- Merchants dealing in the specialized trade of war horses were termed **kudirai chettis** ("horse merchants"). They collaborated with Arab and Portuguese traders.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q9. Which fifteenth-century water storage reservoir stored monsoon runoff to both irrigate surrounding agricultural fields and convey fresh water into the Royal Centre through a masonry aqueduct?

(A) The Hiriya Canal
(B) The Kamalapuram Tank
(C) The Sudarshana Lake
(D) The Malaprabha Reservoir

Sol. Q9. The Kamalapuram Tank:

- The **Kamalapuram Tank**, constructed in the early 15th century, collected runoff to irrigate fields and supplied fresh water directly to the Royal Centre via a stone conduit channel.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q10. Why did Vijayanagara military architects deliberately encircle vast agricultural tracts, orchards, and gardens within the outer rings of fortification walls?

(A) To prevent agricultural peasants from fleeing the empire during harvest
(B) To prevent the escape of wild forest animals into urban residential streets
(C) To ensure an uninterrupted internal food supply during prolonged enemy sieges
(D) To provide grazing lands exclusively for royal hunting leopards

Sol. Q10. Agricultural Enclosure Rationale:

- Medieval sieges sought to starve fortified garrisons into capitulation.
- By enclosing agricultural tracts within the outer fortress walls, Vijayanagara maintained an internal food supply, rendering enemy sieges ineffective.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Part 3: Sacred Architecture & The Fall of the City (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. In the Royal Centre of Vijayanagara, which monumental stone platform was the focal center of royal rituals during the ten-day autumn Dussehra/Navaratri festival?

(A) The Mahanavami Dibba
(B) The Lotus Mahal
(C) The Hazara Rama Platform
(D) The Queen's Bath Platform

Sol. Q11. The Mahanavami Dibba:

- The **Mahanavami Dibba** is a colossal 40-foot-high granite platform where the King performed state rituals, watched wrestling, reviewed the armed forces, and received tribute during the ten-day **Mahanavami** festival.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Q12. Which elegant two-storied structure in the Royal Centre synthesized traditional Dravidian stone brackets with Indo-Islamic cusped arches and was identified by Colin Mackenzie as a council chamber?

(A) The Elephant Stables
(B) The Lotus Mahal
(C) The Hazara Rama Temple
(D) The Zenana Enclosure Gateway

Sol. Q12. The Lotus Mahal:

- The **Lotus Mahal** is an exquisite pavilion combining Dravidian architecture with Indo-Islamic vaulted cusped arches. Mackenzie suggested it functioned as an executive council chamber.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

Q13. Which temple situated in the heart of the Royal Centre was used exclusively by the King and his family, featuring exquisite interior relief carvings narrating scenes from the Ramayana?

(A) Virupaksha Temple
(B) Vitthala Temple
(C) Hazara Rama Temple
(D) Pampadevi Temple

Sol. Q13. The Hazara Rama Temple:

- The **Hazara Rama Temple** served as the private royal family shrine, adorned with interior wall reliefs depicting dramatic episodes from the **Ramayana**.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

Q14. The celebrated Vitthala Temple complex at Vijayanagara is dedicated to a manifestation of Vishnu who was traditionally worshipped in which regional territory?

(A) Tamil Nadu
(B) Orissa
(C) Gujarat
(D) Maharashtra

Sol. Q14. Provenance of Vitthala:

- Lord **Vitthala** is a manifestation of Vishnu traditionally worshipped in **Maharashtra** (at Pandharpur).
- The incorporation of this deity at Vijayanagara highlights the empire's cosmopolitan cultural assimilation.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

Q15. What was the term for the monumental, soaring gateway towers constructed by Vijayanagara rulers that towered over temple complexes and broadcast royal patronage across miles?

(A) Rayagopurams
(B) Garbhagrihas
(C) Kalyana Mandapas
(D) Shikharas

Sol. Q15. Rayagopurams:

- The colossal gateway towers built by Vijayanagara monarchs were termed **rayagopurams** (royal gopurams), signaling imperial patronage from great distances.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**